circumstances where nuclear weapons were already being used from and against Cuba.[49] Seen in this light, Castro's declaration might be considered a variation on a 'full retaliatory response'. When, in the 1990s, it was publicly suggested that he wanted a pre-emptive nuclear attack on America, he suspected this was designed to further discredit him in the eyes of Americans. So, before he appeared at the 1992 Havana conference, he arranged the release of his correspondence with Khrushchev.

Building golden bridges

For many years, the conventional wisdom was that President Kennedy stood firm against what Harold Macmillan dubbed 'the weaker brethren,' who called for a trade between missiles in Cuba and missiles in Turkey. The President refused to compromise NATO's security for that of the United States. So it was claimed. At the same time, by agreeing not to invade Cuba in return for the withdrawal of the missiles, he gave Khrushchev a way out. For those in search of lessons from history, this was avoiding appeasement while building a golden bridge. It was certainly less bloody than sawing off people's legs and removing their testicles. There were those, including the Joint Chiefs of Staff, who were aggrieved that Castro remained in power, but the threat of nuclear war receded. And the golden bridge provided a route to détente.

Kennedy's written response to Khrushchev addressed the private letter of 26 October and made no reference to the public letter of 27 October. Roger Hilsman described this as a 'brilliant diplomatic maneuver'.[50] Subsequently, it became known as the Trollope Ploy, so named after a character in a novel by Anthony Trollope, who contrives to take the squeeze of her hand as a proposal of marriage. The provenance of the diplomatic manoeuvre has been attributed to various members of ExComm (Bundy, Ball, Thompson) though Robert Kennedy successfully persuaded history that he was its author. The provenance of the Trollope epithet is less easy to discern. There is something incongruous about the idea of the dynamic New Frontiersmen of Kennedy's Camelot sitting down to read the Chronicles of Barsetshire and their tales of nineteenth-century landed gentry and English